

THE EARLY MODERN WORLD (1450–1750)

Global Power, Religious Reformation, Revolutionary Sovereignty & The Transatlantic Trade



Primary Artifact: The 1375 Catalan Atlas depicting Emperor Mansa Musa of Mali holding a gold nugget, exemplifying pre-colonial African wealth.

OVERARCHING HISTORICAL ENQUIRY:

"How did early modern commerce, religious conflict, and ideological revolution reshape Britain and the global balance of power between 1450 and 1750?"

LESSON	HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & NARRATIVE FOCUS	PRIMARY SOURCE CORE	PAGE REF
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Who held true global power in 1450, and why was Europe trapped on the edge of the world?

Key Enquiry: How did early modern commerce, religious conflict, and ideological revolution reshape Britain and the globe? • Sections 1 & 2:
Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

SECTION 1 ACT 1: CONTEXT & CATALYST (THE EUROCENTRIC MYTH & THE PERIPHERAL PENINSULA)

[1.1] [1.1] In popular imagination, the modern world is often imagined as a European invention. Yet if an alien observer had orbited the earth in the year 1450, Western Europe would have appeared as little more than an impoverished, war-torn, and disease-ravaged peripheral backwater. Europe was still reeling from the demographic shock of the Black Death, which had annihilated between a third and a half of its population just a century earlier. England and France were trapped in the final bloody gasps of the Hundred Years' War; rival baronies fought in the mud, literacy was restricted to a tiny Latin-speaking clerical elite, and London was a smelly, unpaved commercial town of barely 50,000 souls.

[1.2] [1.2] By sharp contrast, the true centers of global wealth, industrial manufacturing, and demographic power lay thousands of miles to the east and south. In 1450, the Mediterranean was not a European lake, but the western terminal of vast afro- Eurasian trade arteries connecting the spices of the Moluccas, the silks of China, and the goldfields of West Africa. European monarchs

possessed neither the naval technology to cross oceans nor the manufactured goods that Asian and African empires desired; Europe had little to offer the world except silver bullion and raw wool.

SOURCE A HISTORICAL PRIMARY Bibliothèque nationale de France •
CARTOGRAPHY Cartographic Department

The Silk Roads and Maritime Eurasian Trade Networks (c. 1450)



Before European ocean navigation, Eurasian commerce flowed along ancient Silk Roads connecting China, India, and Persia to Mediterranean ports. Goods passed through dozens of middlemen and were heavily taxed by Islamic empires, making Asian luxuries rare and expensive in Europe.

HINGE QUESTION: Why did Ottoman control of eastern trade terminals force Western European kingdoms to take terrifying risks on the Atlantic Ocean?

Bibliothèque nationale de France • Department Cartographic Collection •
Cartographic Department Eurasian Trade Archive

SECTION 2 ACT 2: ESCALATION & CONFLICT (THE GIANTS OF THE EAST: MING CHINA & THE OTTOMAN BLITZ)

[2.1] [2.1] The undisputed economic and technological superpower of the fifteenth century was Ming Dynasty China. Ruling over 100 million citizens, China was an urban, bureaucratic, and industrial giant. Between 1405 and 1433, Emperor Yongle dispatched seven monumental naval expeditions commanded by Admiral Zheng He. Zheng He's fleets were staggering: over 300 ships carrying 28,000 men, featuring nine-masted "Treasure Ships" (*baochuan*) up to 400 feet long with watertight bulkheads and magnetic compasses. These fleets sailed effortlessly across the Indian Ocean to India, the Persian Gulf, and the East African coast, distributing silks and blue-and-white porcelain to awe foreign rulers into paying tribute.

[2.2] [2.2] Meanwhile, on Europe's immediate eastern doorstep, a formidable new Islamic superpower was rising: the Ottoman Empire. In May 1453, twenty-one-year-old Sultan Mehmed II deployed gigantic bronze super-cannons and 80,000 soldiers to besiege

Constantinople, the ancient capital of the Byzantine Empire. The city fell on 29 May 1453, ending over 1,100 years of Roman imperial continuity. Mehmed transformed the city into Istanbul, the glittering seat of Ottoman power. Crucially for Europe, the Ottomans now controlled the Bosphorus and Mediterranean trade terminals, imposing hefty customs tariffs and blocking European merchants from accessing the Silk Roads (Source A).

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • LESSON 1

OTTOMAN EMPIRE

The powerful Islamic empire based in Anatolia that captured Constantinople in 1453 and dominated Mediterranean trade.

SILK ROAD

The ancient overland trade route network connecting China and the Far East with Europe through Central Asia.

CARAVAN

A group of merchants and pack animals traveling together for mutual protection across desert and steppe trade routes.

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

EUROCENTRISM

The misleading historical view that interprets world history exclusively from a Western European perspective.

Who held true global power in 1450, and why was Europe trapped on the edge of the world?

SECTION 3 ACT 3: FORENSIC ARCHIVAL EVIDENCE (THE GOLD OF MALI & MANSА MUSA’S RICHES)

[3.1] [3.1] Forensic examination of primary artifacts demonstrates how self-assured the great non-European empires were. In Ming China, Zheng He recorded that imperial fleets had "traversed more than one hundred thousand li of immense waters" to treat distant barbarians with kindness and display "the transforming power of imperial virtue." China had no desire to conquer foreign lands or establish overseas settler colonies because Chinese emperors believed their Middle Kingdom already possessed everything under heaven. Consequently, when Confucian court officials judged the voyages too expensive, the fleet was ordered to rot at anchor and foreign voyages were outlawed in 1433.

[3.2] [3.2] In West Africa, the Mali and Songhai empires commanded immense commercial wealth. The legendary 1324 pilgrimage to Mecca by Emperor Mansa Musa had introduced so much pure gold into Cairo’s economy that the metal’s value was depressed for twelve years! European cartographers in Majorca drew the

famous Catalan Atlas of 1375 (Source B) showing Mansa Musa crowned in gold, brandishing an enormous gold nugget like an apple. African kingdoms like the Kingdom of Benin cast intricate brass and bronze sculptures displaying sophisticated metallurgical mastery that rivaled anything produced in Renaissance Italy.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL 1432–1481



Sultan Mehmed II (The Conqueror)
SULTAN OF THE OTTOMAN EMPIRE (REIGNED 1451–1481)

Captured Constantinople in 1453, ending the Byzantine Empire and placing overland trade routes between Europe and Asia under Ottoman control.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Employed Hungarian cannon-founder Urban to construct massive super-cannons (the "Dardanelles Gun") to shatter the ancient Theodosian Walls.
- Transported Ottoman warships overland on greased logs into the Golden Horn to bypass the Byzantine harbour chain barrier.
- Transformed Constantinople into the imperial capital Istanbul and established commercial dominance over the Eastern Mediterranean trade nexus.

SECTION 4 ACT 4: THE HISTORICAL VERDICT & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE (THE DESPERATION OF THE EDGE)

[4.1] [4.1] Modern global historians, such as Professor Peter Frankopan in *The Silk Roads* (2015), have radically revised traditional Eurocentric narratives. Frankopan demonstrates that for thousands of years, the beating heart of world history was the Eurasian crossroads—Persia, Central Asia, and China—not Western Europe. The European "Age of Discovery" was not the inevitable triumph of European cultural genius; rather, it was born out of profound weakness and geographic desperation. Cut off from Asian trade by the Ottoman superpower, European kingdoms had to gamble on the open, terrifying Atlantic Ocean or remain impoverished forever.

[4.2] [4.2] The year 1450 marks the calm before a global storm. Within fifty years, small, desperate Portuguese and Spanish ships would round the Cape of Good Hope and stumble across the Americas, triggering a violent reordering of the planet. Yet in 1450, the rulers of Beijing, Istanbul, and Timbuktu would have laughed out loud at the suggestion that a tiny island called England would one day build the largest global empire in human history.

COMMERCIAL MECHANISM TRADE MONOPOLIES • 1453

The Fall of Constantinople & The Quest for Sea Routes

Before 1453, Western European merchants relied on Venetian and Genoese trading networks that purchased silk, porcelain, and spices from Asian caravans arriving at Constantinople. Following the Ottoman conquest, Muslim authorities imposed heavy taxes on Christian traders and restricted direct access to the Black Sea and Levant. Faced with soaring spice prices and bullion drain, Atlantic kingdoms (Portugal and Spain) realized they could not break the Venetian-Ottoman monopoly overland. This commercial bottleneck directly triggered the Age of Discovery as navigators sought direct maritime passages to India around Africa or across the Atlantic.

Key Causation: Ottoman control of the overland Silk Road transformed Western Europe from a peripheral, landlocked backwater into an aggressive maritime explorer civilization.

ARCHIVAL DISPATCH EYEWITNESS MERCHANT CHRONICLE May 1453

Niccolò Barbaro’s Diary of the Siege of Constantinople

"On the twenty-ninth of May, 1453, the sun had not yet risen when the Turks entered the city through the San Romano gate... The blood flowed in the city like rainwater in the gutters after a sudden storm. The great church of Hagia Sophia was filled with captives, and the ancient empire of the Romans has ceased to exist."

Biblioteca Marciana, Venice (Codex Marcianus) Constantinople, May 1453

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT			LESSON 1 SYNTHESIS
1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE: Why was the geographical position of Constantinople so crucial for Eurasian trade in 1450?	2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS: Explain how the Catalan Atlas (1375) reveals the immense wealth of West African empires like Mali.	3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE: Historians argue whether 1450 was an era of European superiority or European insignificance. Evaluate which interpretation has stronger historical evidence.	

How useful are Sources A and B for investigating why European rulers risked everything to cross the oceans (1494–1588)?

Key Enquiry: How did early modern commerce, religious conflict, and ideological revolution reshape Britain and the globe? • Sections 1 & 2:
Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

SECTION 1 ACT 1: CONTEXT & CATALYST (LUTHER'S HAMMER & THE PAPAL MONOPOLY)

[1.1] [1.1] In October 1517, an obscure German monk named Martin Luther nailed ninety-five theses to the church door in Wittenberg, attacking the corruption of the Catholic papacy. Luther argued that salvation was achieved through personal faith alone, not by purchasing papal indulgences or submitting to Roman hierarchy. Luther's protest ignited the **Protestant Reformation**, tearing Europe into two violently hostile religious camps: Catholic kingdoms loyal to the Pope (led by the mighty Habsburg superpower of Spain), and Protestant states (eventually including England, Scotland, the Netherlands, and northern Germany) who viewed the Pope as the Antichrist.

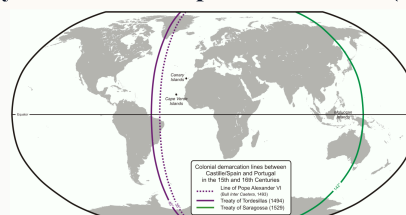
[1.2] [1.2] Meanwhile, Spain and Portugal had already struck maritime gold. In 1494, Pope Alexander VI mediated the **Treaty of Tordesillas** (Source A), audaciously drawing an imaginary meridian line down the Atlantic Ocean: all non-Christian lands discovered to the west belonged exclusively to Spain, while everything to the east belonged to Portugal. Spanish conquistadors

like Cortés and Pizarro annihilated the Aztec and Inca empires, establishing a colossal silver-mining empire in Mexico and Peru. To Spanish King Philip II, this tidal wave of silver was not merely cash: it was divine funding provided by God to build invincible armies and crush Protestant heretics worldwide.

SOURCE A DIPLOMATIC IMPERIAL General Archive of the Indies, Seville • Patronato 1-1-1

TREATY MAP

The Treaty of Tordesillas Papal Meridian Line (1494)



Brokered by Pope Alexander VI in 1494, the Treaty of Tordesillas divided the non-Christian world between Spain and Portugal along a meridian 370 leagues west of Cape Verde, granting Spain the Americas and Portugal Brazil, Africa, and the Indian Ocean trade.

HINGE QUESTION: Why did Protestant monarchs like Elizabeth I view the papal partition of the world as illegitimate and an act of war?

General Archive of the Indies, Seville • Iberian Maritime & Imperial Treaties Patronato 1-1-1 Collection

SECTION 2 ACT 2: ESCALATION & CONFLICT (THE SEA DOGS: PIRACY IN GOD'S NAME)

[2.1] [2.1] In England, King Henry VIII broke with Rome in 1534 to secure a divorce, declaring himself Supreme Head of the Church of England. By the time his daughter Elizabeth I ascended the throne in 1558, England was a vulnerable Protestant island surrounded by powerful Catholic enemies. Excommunicated by Pope Pius V in 1570—who commanded English Catholics to depose their "heretic queen"—Elizabeth could not afford a full-scale war against Spain's legendary infantry, the *tercios*. Instead, she turned to state-sponsored maritime piracy.

[2.2] [2.2] Elizabeth secretly licensed audacious Devon sea captains—the infamous "**Sea Dogs**", including Sir Francis Drake and Sir John Hawkins. Armed with royal letters of marque, Drake ambushed Spanish treasure galleons in the Caribbean, looted silver mule-trains in Panama, and between 1577 and 1580 became the first Englishman to circumnavigate the globe in the *Golden Hind*. When Drake returned to Plymouth laden with tons

of looted Spanish silver—yielding an astonishing 4,700 percent return on investment—Philip II furiously demanded his head. Instead, Elizabeth brazenly boarded Drake's ship in London and knighted him on his own quarterdeck, openly mocking the Spanish superpower!

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • LESSON 2

REFORMATION

The 16th-century religious movement launched by Martin Luther that challenged papal authority and created Protestantism.

CONQUISTADOR

Spanish military adventurer who conquered indigenous American civilizations in Mexico and Peru during the 1500s.

BULLION

Gold or silver in mass quantities (bars or ingots) valued by weight rather than nominal face currency value.

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

PRIVATEER

An armed private ship licensed by an official government letter of marque to attack enemy commercial shipping.

How useful are Sources A and B for investigating why European rulers risked everything to cross the oceans (1494–1588)?

SECTION 3

ACT 3: FORENSIC ARCHIVAL EVIDENCE (THE ARMADA PORTRAIT & THE PROTESTANT WIND)

[3.1] [3.1] Enraged by English piracy, Elizabeth's military support for Dutch Protestant rebels, and the execution of Catholic Mary Queen of Scots in 1587, Philip II launched his "Enterprise of England" in July 1588: the Spanish Armada. A colossal fleet of 130 warships carrying 30,000 soldiers sailed up the English Channel in an unbreakable crescent formation, intending to ferry an invasion army across from Flanders and restore Catholicism to England at sword-point. But off Calais on 7 August, English commanders launched eight blazing hellburner fireships into the anchored Armada, throwing the Spanish galleons into midnight panic and scattering their formations.

[3.2] [3.2] The next day at the Battle of Gravelines, faster English race-built galleons pounded the disorganized Spanish ships at long range. Battered and blown northward by ferocious North Sea gales, the Armada was forced to attempt a catastrophic voyage home around the rocky coasts of Scotland and Ireland, where dozens of ships were smashed to kindling on the

Atlantic rocks. The triumphant English struck a commemorative medal reading: "God blew, and they were scattered." In the famous **Armada Portrait** (Source B), Elizabeth is immortalized surrounded by royal pearls, her hand resting upon the global Americas while the shattered Spanish fleet flounders in tempestuous seas behind her.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

c. 1540–1596



Sir Francis Drake
ELIZABETHAN PRIVATEER, NAVIGATOR & VICE-ADMIRAL OF THE ENGLISH FLEET

Circumnavigated the globe (1577–1580), raided Spanish silver shipments along the Pacific coast, and played a decisive role defeating the Spanish Armada.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Captured the Spanish galleon **Nuestra Señora de la Concepción** ("Cacafuego"), seizing twenty-six tons of uncoined silver bullion and eighty pounds of gold.
- Knighted by Queen Elizabeth I aboard his flagship **The Golden Hind** at Deptford in 1581, defying Spanish demands for his execution as a pirate.
- Executed the daring fire-ship attack against the Spanish Armada at Gravelines in 1588, scattering the Spanish crescent formation.

SECTION 4

ACT 4: THE HISTORICAL VERDICT & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE (RELIGIOUS CRUSADE OR IMPERIAL RIVALRY?)

[4.1] [4.1] Historians debate whether the Elizabethan naval struggle was primarily motivated by genuine religious zeal or by naked financial greed. Victorian historians painted Elizabeth's Sea Dogs as Protestant freedom fighters standing bravely against Spanish Catholic tyranny. However, modern economic historians point out that Drake and Hawkins were primarily commercial opportunists and slave traders whose religious rhetoric conveniently justified ruthless robbery on the high seas.

[4.2] [4.2] Nevertheless, the psychological impact of 1588 was profound. The defeat of the Armada shattered the aura of Spanish naval invincibility and proved to English merchants that the Atlantic was open. For the first time, English investors began to dream of establishing permanent overseas colonies, laying the ideological and commercial foundations for what would become the British Empire.

GLOBAL ECONOMY

THE SILVER PIPELINE • 1545–1600

The Cerro Rico of Potosí & The Spanish Price Revolution

In 1545, Spanish colonizers discovered Cerro Rico in Potosí (modern Bolivia)—a mountain of pure silver ore. Using the brutal **mita** forced-labour system, millions of indigenous and enslaved African miners extracted thousands of tons of silver. Spanish silver fleets (the **Flota de Indias**) transported this wealth to Seville, funding Philip II's Catholic crusades against Dutch Protestant rebels, Ottoman navies, and Tudor England. However, this massive influx of bullion tripled European money supply, causing catastrophic "Price Revolution" inflation while failing to build long-term Spanish industry.

Economic Mechanism: New World silver funded Spanish global hegemony, but created acute geopolitical envy: English state-sponsored privateers targeted Spanish treasure fleets as an act of holy and commercial war.

ARCHIVAL DISPATCH

ROYAL ORATION

9 August 1588

Queen Elizabeth I's Address to the Troops at Tilbury

"I know I have the body but of a weak and feeble woman; but I have the heart and stomach of a king, and of a king of England too, and think foul scorn that Parma or Spain, or any prince of Europe, should dare to invade the borders of my realm."

British Library, London (Harleian MS 6798)

Camp at Tilbury, Essex

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT			LESSON 2 SYNTHESIS
1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE: How did the Protestant Reformation split Western Europe into competing ideological blocs after 1517?	2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS: Explain why English privateering under Elizabeth I was considered piracy by Spain but patriotic defense by England.	3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE: Evaluate whether weather ("the Protestant Wind") or English naval tactics were the decisive cause of the Spanish Armada's defeat in 1588.	

Trade or takeover: How did humble English trading posts turn into a corporate empire?

Key Enquiry: How did early modern commerce, religious conflict, and ideological revolution reshape Britain and the globe? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

SECTION 1 ACT 1: CONTEXT & CATALYST (THE JOINT-STOCK INNOVATION & THE LONDON MERCHANTS)

[1.1] [1.1] At the turn of the seventeenth century, English overseas expansion underwent an institutional revolution. Monarchs like Elizabeth I and James I were chronically broke; they could never finance state-run fleets like the Spanish Crown. Instead, London merchants pioneered a radical capitalist financial vehicle: the joint-stock company. Rather than a single merchant risking his entire fortune on a perilous three-year oceanic voyage, hundreds of investors bought transferable company shares. If a ship sank or was seized by pirates, an investor lost only what they had invested; if the ship returned laden with cloves, nutmeg, or silk, the profits were divided proportionally. This spread of financial risk unlocked immense pools of private capital.

[1.2] [1.2] On New Year's Eve 1600, Elizabeth I signed a royal charter creating "The Governor and Company of Merchants of London trading into the East Indies" –the **East India Company (EIC)**. Granted a royal monopoly on all English trade east of the Cape of Good Hope, the EIC sailed into the Indian Ocean not with royal armies, but

with ledgers, silver coins, and cargo manifests. Six years later in 1606, King James I chartered the **Virginia Company of London** to establish private profitable colonies along the North American Atlantic coast, erecting the fortified settlement at Jamestown (Source A).

SOURCE A ARCHAEOLOGICAL MILITARY Virginia Historical Society
SURVEY Archives

Archaeological Plan of James Fort, Virginia (1607)



England's first permanent North American settlement was built as a triangular palisade fort armed with artillery at each corner on the James River. The settlers faced disease, drought, and conflict with the Powhatan confederacy, barely surviving until commercial tobacco cultivation brought stability.

HINGE QUESTION: How does the military design of James Fort prove that English colonization relied on armed defense rather than peaceful trade?

Virginia Historical Society Archives Colonial Jamestown Archaeological Record

SECTION 2 ACT 2: ESCALATION & CONFLICT (JAMESTOWN'S STARVATION & THE MUGHAL COLOSSUS)

[2.1] [2.1] England's initial colonial venture was an unmitigated disaster. In May 1607, three small Virginia Company ships landed 104 wealthy gentlemen, jewelers, and servants in Virginia, founding Jamestown. Expecting to discover gold and rubies like Spanish conquistadors, the pampered gentlemen refused to plant crops or dig wells. By winter, over half had perished from dysentery and starvation. During the horrific "Starving Time" of 1609–1610, desperate settlers ate roots, rats, their own leather boots, and in one gruesome instance, a settler reportedly cannibalized his deceased wife! The colony was saved from total annihilation only when John Rolfe crossbred a sweet Caribbean tobacco strain, sparking an addictive European cash-crop craze that turned Virginia into an agrarian boomtown hungry for indigenous land.

[2.2] [2.2] Meanwhile on the other side of the planet, the East India Company encountered a civilization that made London look like a village: the **Mughal Empire** in India. Ruling over 150 million subjects—a fifth of

humanity—the Mughal Empire commanded an economy generating 25 percent of the world's industrial output, famous for exquisite calico cottons, raw silk, and indigo. When English ships arrived off Gujarat, local governors viewed the newcomers as ragged coastal peddlers. To secure permanent trading footholds, King James I dispatched an aristocratic ambassador, Sir Thomas Roe, in 1615 to the glittering imperial court at Agra.

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • LESSON 3

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

CHARTERED COMPANY

A commercial corporation granted exclusive trading monopolies and sovereign territorial rights by royal decree.

KINGDOM OF BENIN

A sophisticated pre-colonial West African forest kingdom (modern Nigeria) renowned for monumental bronze art.

FACTORY

A fortified early modern overseas trading outpost and warehouse managed by merchant agents called factors.

MONOPOLY

The exclusive legal control of the supply or trade in a commodity or service in a particular territory.

Trade or takeover: How did humble English trading posts turn into a corporate empire?

SECTION 3 ACT 3: FORENSIC ARCHIVAL EVIDENCE (THE TRIANGULAR FORT & THE AGRA AUDIENCE)

[3.1] [3.1] Primary documents expose the immense vulnerability of early English expansion. The original architectural blueprint of Jamestown (Source A) shows a rigid triangular fort bristling with artillery bastions at each corner. This was not a monument to imperial conquest, but a desperate panic shelter: surrounded by the powerful Powhatan Confederacy and terrified of Catholic Spanish galleons, English settlers lived locked behind wooden palisades, dependent on trading copper kettles and glass beads to Chief Powhatan for baskets of life-saving corn.

[3.2] [3.2] An even sharper contrast is documented in Sir Thomas Roe’s journals from the court of Mughal Emperor Jahangir (Source B). Roe was stunned by the unimaginable luxury of the Mughal court: Jahangir sat upon golden thrones encrusted with diamonds and emeralds, surrounded by thousands of courtiers. Roe’s English gifts—heavy woollen cloth and a clockwork coach

—were regarded by the Emperor with mild amusement as primitive curiosities. Jahangir eventually granted the Company an imperial *farman* (decree) allowing them to construct a "factory" (a fortified trading warehouse) at Surat, not out of fear, but because the Mughals welcomed foreign silver bullion into their treasury.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

16th Century



Oba of Benin (Esigie / Ewuare Dynasty)
SOVEREIGN MONARCH OF THE KINGDOM OF BENIN (EDO STATE, WEST AFRICA)

Governed a sophisticated, highly fortified imperial city that engaged in diplomatic and trade parity with Portuguese and Dutch merchants.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Enforced strict state monopolies over ivory, pepper, and bronze trade, preventing European traders from penetrating inland.
- Commissioned the world-renowned Benin Bronzes—intricate brass relief plaques documenting court ritual, military conquests, and foreign traders.
- Established formal diplomatic exchanges, dispatching an Edo ambassador to the Royal Court of King John II in Lisbon.

SECTION 4 ACT 4: THE HISTORICAL VERDICT & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE (AN EMPIRE IN A FIT OF ABSENCE OF MIND?)

[4.1] [4.1] In 1883, imperial historian Sir John Seeley coined a famous historical aphorism: "We seem, as it were, to have conquered and peopled half the world in a fit of absence of mind." Seeley argued that the British Empire was never a pre-meditated government conspiracy; it emerged organically from the dispersed, private initiatives of adventurous merchants and desperate settlers who merely wanted to buy spices and grow tobacco.

[4.2] [4.2] Modern post-colonial historians, such as Professor Shashi Tharoor, present a far more critical interpretation. They demonstrate that while expansion began as trade, the logic of capitalist monopolies made territorial conquest inevitable. To protect their commercial profits, corporate trading posts like the East India Company built private mercenary armies, constructed stone forts, and bribed or intimidated local rulers. Over the next 150 years, the company’s accounting clerks would gradually transform themselves into imperial rulers, setting the stage for the total colonial conquest of the Indian subcontinent.

INSTITUTIONAL EVOLUTION

CHARTERED CORPORATIONS • 1600

The East India Company: From Merchants to Sovereign Rulers

On 31 December 1600, Elizabeth I granted a royal monopoly charter to the "Governor and Company of Merchants of London Trading into the East Indies". Unlike Crown-funded Spanish conquests, English expansion was privatized and profit-driven. The Company established fortified trading stations ("factories") at Surat, Madras, and Calcutta by negotiating *firmans* (royal permits) with Mughal emperors. Over the 17th and 18th centuries, the Company raised its own private armies of European officers and Indian *sepoys*, transforming from a spice-trading partnership into an aggressive territorial empire with sovereign taxation powers.

Imperial Mechanism: British imperial expansion in Asia was not initiated by the British government, but by a joint-stock corporate monopoly driven by shareholder dividends and military force.

ARCHIVAL DISPATCH

DUTCH MERCHANT ACCOUNT

Circa 1602

Olfert Dapper’s Description of the City of Benin

"The king's palace is a collection of buildings occupying as much space as the town of Haarlem... The town is composed of thirty main streets, very straight and 120 feet wide. The houses are close to one another, arranged in good order, and clean as Flemish homes."

Nationaal Archief, The Hague

Description of Africa (Amsterdam, 1668)

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT LESSON 3 SYNTHESIS

- 1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE:**
Describe the sophisticated urban design and trade relations of the Kingdom of Benin in the 16th century.
- 2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS:**
Explain how joint-stock chartered companies (like the East India Company) differed from traditional monarchical conquests.
- 3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE:**
"Early modern European encounters with non-Europeans were based entirely on exploitation, not mutual trade." Assess this historical interpretation.

Why was religious division such an explosive threat under King James I?

Key Enquiry: How did early modern commerce, religious conflict, and ideological revolution reshape Britain and the globe? • Sections 1 & 2:
Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

SECTION 1 THE ELIZABETHAN RECUSANCY LAWS & STUART SUCCESSION

[1.1] During the reign of Queen Elizabeth I, England became a strictly enforced Protestant state. Following the 1570 Papal Bull excommunicating Elizabeth, the Tudor government viewed English Catholics with intense suspicion as potential traitors and foreign agents. Draconian penal laws were enacted: heavy recusancy fines were levied on any subject who refused to attend Anglican Sunday services, and harboring Catholic Jesuit priests was declared high treason punishable by being hanged, drawn, and quartered. Wealthy Catholic families were financially drained, forced to construct secret "priest holes" within their manor houses, and barred from public office.

[1.2] When Elizabeth died childless in March 1603, the crown passed to her Scottish cousin King James VI, who became King James I of England. English Catholics initially celebrated the Stuart succession, recalling that James was the son of the executed Catholic Mary Queen of Scots and had privately hinted at religious tolerance. However, James quickly discovered that relaxing the penal laws enraged hardline Puritan Members of

Parliament, whose financial subsidies he desperately required. In February 1604, James issued a royal proclamation expelling all Catholic priests from England and vigorously reimposed the hated recusancy fines, shattering Catholic hopes for peaceful coexistence.

SOURCE A

CONTEMPORARY DUTCH National Portrait Gallery, London • NPG D25492

ENGRAVING

Crispijn van de Passe: The Gunpowder Plot Conspirators (1605)



This 1605 print depicts Robert Catesby, Guy Fawkes, Thomas Percy, and fellow conspirators plotting in secret. Disillusioned by King James I's continuation of Elizabethan anti-Catholic penal laws, the conspirators smuggled thirty-six barrels of gunpowder beneath the House of Lords.

HINGE QUESTION: Does this engraving present the conspirators as desperate religious martyrs or dangerous traitors to the state?

National Portrait Gallery, London • NPG Jacobean State Trials & Treason D25492 Archive

SECTION 2 THE CONSPIRACY IN THE CELLAR BENEATH PARLIAMENT

[2.1] Enraged by King James's perceived betrayal, charismatic Warwickshire Catholic gentleman Robert Catesby resolved to strike a catastrophic, decapitating blow against the Protestant establishment. In May 1604, Catesby met secretly with four fellow conspirators at the Duck and Drake inn in the Strand, swearing an oath of secrecy upon a Catholic primer. The cell grew to include thirteen plotters, including military munitions veteran Guy (Guido) Fawkes, who had spent a decade fighting for Catholic Spain in the Low Countries and possessed specialized knowledge of military mining and gunpowder.

[2.2] In March 1605, conspirator Thomas Percy leased a ground-floor coal cellar directly beneath the House of Lords. Under cover of darkness, Fawkes supervised the covert transport of thirty-six heavy barrels of gunpowder across the River Thames from Lambeth, concealing them beneath piles of iron billets, coal, and firewood. The conspiracy was breathtaking in its scale and ruthlessness: when King James, Queen Anne, Prince Henry, the

bishops, judges, and Members of Parliament gathered for the State Opening of Parliament, Fawkes was to ignite a slow match and escape by boat. Simultaneously, conspirators in the Midlands would kidnap nine-year-old Princess Elizabeth to install her as a puppet Catholic queen.

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • LESSON 4

RECUSANCY

The refusal of Roman Catholics in England to attend Anglican Church of England Sunday services, punished by heavy fines.

DIVINE RIGHT

The theological doctrine that monarchs derive their authority directly from God and are accountable to no earthly power.

TREASON

The crime of betraying one's country or sovereign monarch, punishable in early modern Britain by hanging, drawing, and quartering.

POPISH PLOT

A recurrent early modern English Protestant fear of covert Catholic conspiracies to assassinate the monarch and subvert Protestantism.

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

Why was religious division such an explosive threat under King James I?

SECTION 3 THE MONTEAGLE LETTER & INTERROGATION IN THE TOWER

[3.1] On Saturday 26 October 1605, Catholic peer Lord Monteagle was dining at his home in Hoxton when a servant handed him an anonymous letter delivered by a cloaked stranger. The letter warned Monteagle: "they shall receive a terrible blow this Parliament and yet they shall not see who hurts them." Recognizing the existential peril, Monteagle took the warning directly to Robert Cecil, Earl of Salisbury, King James's Spymaster. Cecil waited until midnight on 4 November before dispatching a search party led by Sir Thomas Knyvett to search the vaults of Parliament.

[3.2] In the dark cellar, Knyvett discovered Guy Fawkes booted and cloaked, carrying a pocket watch, touchwood, and slow fuses beside thirty-six barrels of powder. Fawkes was immediately arrested and taken to the Tower of London. King James issued a handwritten royal warrant ordering the Lieutenant of the Tower to extract the names of the conspirators, specifying that "the gentler tortures are first to be used unto him... and so by

degrees proceeding to what is worse." Strapped to the agonizing rack, Fawkes endured days of torture before his spirit broke. His second signature on the confession was a faint, trembling scrawl ("Guido"), bearing witness to the catastrophic physical destruction of his body.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

1572–1605



Robert Catesby

LEADER OF THE GUNPOWDER PLOT CONSPIRATORS

Charismatic Catholic gentleman who conceived the conspiracy to blow up the King and Parliament to restore a Catholic monarch.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Enraged by King James I's failure to repeal harsh Elizabethan anti-Catholic recusancy fines and banishment of Catholic priests.
- Recruited a network of radicalized Catholic gentry, including explosive munitions specialist Guy Fawkes, leasing a cellar directly under the House of Lords.
- Conspired to place King James's nine-year-old daughter Princess Elizabeth on the throne as a puppet Catholic queen following the explosion.
- Fled London following Fawkes's arrest, making a defiant final armed stand with fellow conspirators at Holbeche House in Staffordshire, where he was shot dead in battle.

SECTION 4 THE AFTERMATH, EXECUTIONS & ANTI-CATHOLIC LEGACY

[4.1] The failure of the Gunpowder Plot unleashed a fierce wave of anti-Catholic hysteria across Jacobean Britain. Robert Catesby and several fellow plotters fled to Holbeche House in Staffordshire, where they made a desperate last stand in the rain; Catesby was shot dead with his sword drawn. The surviving conspirators, including Guy Fawkes, were tried for high treason in Westminster Hall in January 1606 and condemned to the traitor's death, being dragged through the streets on hurdles before being hanged and quartered at St Paul's Churchyard and the Old Palace Yard.

[4.2] Parliament capitalized on the national panic to pass the draconian Popish Recusants Act of 1606, forbidding Catholics from practicing law, medicine, serving as army officers, or voting in parliamentary elections. A mandatory Oath of Allegiance was imposed requiring Catholics to explicitly deny the Pope's authority to depose English monarchs. Furthermore, Parliament enacted the Observance of 5th November Act, mandating an annual church service of thanksgiving for Britain's miraculous deliverance. The celebratory bonfire and effigy-burning tradition that took root in November 1605

established a lasting patriotic ritual that defined British identity for over three centuries.

SECURITY STATE

THE REPRESSIVE APPARATUS • 1605

The Monteagle Letter & The Espionage Network

On 26 October 1605, Catholic peer Lord Monteagle received an anonymous letter warning him: "they shall receive a terrible blow this Parliament and yet they shall not see who hurts them." Monteagle immediately delivered the warning to Robert Cecil, Earl of Salisbury, James I's Spymaster. Cecil waited until midnight on 4 November before ordering a search of Parliament's cellars, capturing Guy Fawkes guarding thirty-six barrels of gunpowder. Some historians argue Cecil knew of the plot weeks earlier through double agents and allowed it to mature to maximize public anti-Catholic fury and pass draconian security laws. Cecil skillfully exploited the conspiracy to create an enduring Protestant security state, uniting a fractured nation behind King James I.

Political Consequence: The discovery of the plot cemented anti-Catholic nationalism in the English Protestant psyche, resulting in the Popish Recusants Act and institutionalized exclusion of Catholics from public life for over two centuries.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT

1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE:

What grievances drove Robert Catesby and his fellow conspirators to plot the destruction of Parliament?

2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS:

Explain why the discovery of thirty-six barrels of gunpowder beneath Parliament was exploited by Robert Cecil.

3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE:

Evaluate whether the Gunpowder Plot was primarily a response to state religious persecution or an act of radical sectarian terrorism.

LESSON 4 SYNTHESIS

How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 that the Civil War was an unavoidable fight against royal tyranny?

Key Enquiry: How did early modern commerce, religious conflict, and ideological revolution reshape Britain and the globe? • Sections 1 & 2:
Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

SECTION 1 ACT 1: CONTEXT & CATALYST (THE ARROGANT MONARCH & THE ELEVEN YEARS' TYRANNY)

[1.1] [1.1] In 1625, King Charles I succeeded his father James. Rigid, aloof, and intensely insecure, Charles held an uncompromising belief in the **Divine Right of Kings**: he genuinely believed that the monarch was accountable only to God, and that questioning royal policy was equivalent to blasphemy. When MPs in the House of Commons refused to grant him taxation without redressing grievances, Charles dissolved Parliament in 1629 and embarked on eleven years of personal governance known as the **"Eleven Years' Tyranny"** (Personal Rule).

[1.2] [1.2] To fund his royal court without summoning Parliament, Charles resurrected ancient, obsolete feudal levies. His most controversial tactic was levying Ship Money : traditionally a medieval tax paid exclusively by coastal towns during wartime to construct warships, Charles illegally extended the tax to inland counties in peacetime! When Buckinghamshire landowner John Hampden refused to pay twenty shillings on principle in

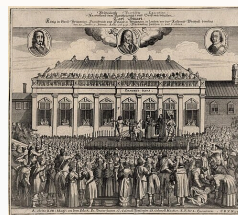
1637, he was prosecuted by royal judges. Millions of Englishmen concluded that Charles was seeking to strip away their historic liberties and establish a French-style absolute Catholic tyranny.

SOURCE A

CONTEMPORARY British Museum • Department of Prints & Drawings

EYEWITNESS ENGRAVING

Contemporary German Engraving: The Execution of Charles I (1649)



On 30 January 1649, King Charles I was beheaded on a scaffold outside the Banqueting House in Whitehall before a stunned crowd. Condemned by Parliament's High Court of Justice as a "tyrant, traitor, murderer, and public enemy", his death ended the absolute Divine Right of Kings.

HINGE QUESTION: How did the public execution of a crowned monarch destroy the concept of the Divine Right of Kings forever?

British Museum • Department of Prints & Drawings • Civil War & Regicide Collection • 1649

SECTION 2 ACT 2: ESCALATION & CONFLICT (THE KINGDOM IN BLOOD & THE TRIAL OF THE TYRANT)

[2.1] [2.1] War became unavoidable in January 1642 when Charles stormed into the House of Commons with 400 armed guards to arrest five leading MPs for treason—only to find that "the birds had flown." In August 1642, Charles raised his royal standard at Nottingham, plunging England into seven years of horrific Civil War. The nation fractured: **Cavaliers** (Royalists supporting the Crown and Church of England) fought **Roundheads** (Parliamentarians and Puritans fighting for liberty and parliamentary supremacy). Over 200,000 Englishmen died from combat and disease—a higher proportion of the population than Britain lost in World War I.

[2.2] [2.2] Parliament triumphed through military innovation: Oliver Cromwell created the **New Model Army**, a professional, disciplined force of godly soldiers promoted on merit rather than aristocratic birth. The New Model Army crushed the Royalists at Naseby (1645). When Charles secretly plotted with Scottish invaders to start a second civil war, Cromwell and hardline army

officers decided that peace was impossible while the King lived. In December 1648, Colonel Pride barred moderate MPs from Parliament ("Pride's Purge"), leaving a radical "Rump Parliament" that created a High Court of Justice to put Charles I on trial for high treason, sentencing the King to be beheaded outside Whitehall (Source A).

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • LESSON 5

PERSONAL RULE

The eleven-year period (1629–1640) during which King Charles I governed England without summoning Parliament.

SHIP MONEY

A traditional coastal defense tax extended controversially by Charles I to all inland English counties during peacetime.

CAVALIERS

Royalist supporters of King Charles I during the English Civil War, drawn largely from the aristocracy and gentry.

ROUNDHEADS

Supporters of Parliament during the English Civil War, so named because many Puritan apprentices wore short hair.

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 that the Civil War was an unavoidable fight against royal tyranny?

SECTION 3

ACT 3: FORENSIC ARCHIVAL EVIDENCE (THE AXE FALLS & THE SEAL OF THE COMMONWEALTH)

[3.1] [3.1] At his trial in Westminster Hall, Charles refused to remove his hat or enter a plea, haughtily demanding: "By what lawful authority am I brought hither? No earthly power can justly call me, who am your King, to account." But the court declared him a "tyrant, traitor, murderer, and public enemy." On 30 January 1649, Charles was marched onto a scaffold outside the Banqueting House at Whitehall (Source A). Showing dignified courage, Charles requested two shirts because the morning was freezing: "The season is so sharp as probably may make me shake, which some observers will imagine proceeds from fear. I would have no such imputation!" The masked executioner severed his head with one clean blow.

[3.2] [3.2] For the next eleven years, England was a republic: the **Commonwealth**. As captured in the Great Seal of 1651 (Source B), royal symbols were systematically obliterated: the seal depicted the House of Commons in session rather than a monarch on

horseback. But liberty proved elusive. Cromwell dismissed Parliament by military force in 1653, declaring himself **Lord Protector**—ruling as a military dictator, dividing England into eleven military districts governed by puritan Major-Generals who banned Christmas, horse racing, and theatre.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL1600–1649



King Charles I
KING OF ENGLAND, SCOTLAND, AND IRELAND (REIGNED 1625–1649)

Believed unswervingly in the Divine Right of Kings, ruled without Parliament for eleven years, and was executed for high treason in 1649.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Instituted "Personal Rule" (1629–1640), funding government through controversial feudal taxes like Ship Money levied on inland towns.
- Attempted to arrest five MPs in the House of Commons in January 1642, violating parliamentary privilege and triggering the English Civil War.
- Tried before the High Court of Justice in Westminster Hall; refused to plead, arguing no earthly court possessed lawful authority to judge God's anointed King.

SECTION 4

ACT 4: THE HISTORICAL VERDICT & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE (THE GLORIOUS REVOLUTION OF 1688)

[4.1] [4.1] Exhausted by Puritan military rule, England restored Charles II to the throne in the **Restoration of 1660**. Yet the constitutional question remained unresolved until 1688. When Charles II's Catholic brother, **James II**, attempted to suspend laws and rule without Parliament, MPs invited Dutch Prince **William of Orange** and his wife Mary (James's Protestant daughter) to invade England in the **Glorious Revolution of 1688**. James II fled into exile without a fight.

[4.2] [4.2] In 1689, William and Mary accepted the historic **Bill of Rights**. The statute permanently transformed Britain into a **constitutional monarchy**: the monarch could never suspend laws, levy taxes without Parliament, or maintain a standing army in peacetime. Freedom of speech in parliamentary debate was guaranteed forever. The bloody ideological struggle that began with Charles I's divine pretensions in 1629 ended with the supreme authority of Parliament firmly etched into British law.

CONSTITUTIONAL CRISISREGICIDE • JANUARY 1649

The Trial of the King: Shattering Divine Right

On 20 January 1649, Charles I was brought before a specially assembled High Court of Justice presided over by John Bradshaw. The prosecution, led by John Cook, charged Charles as a "tyrant, traitor, murderer, and public enemy to the good people of this nation" for waging war against his own subjects. Charles defiantly challenged the court: "I would know by what power I am called hither... by what legal authority?" Fifty-nine commissioners signed the King's death warrant. On 30 January 1649, Charles was beheaded outside the Banqueting House in Whitehall, establishing the radical precedent that English rulers are subject to the law of the land.

Constitutional Significance: Regicide destroyed the mystical inviolability of the monarchy. Even when the crown was restored in 1660, no future monarch could govern without Parliament's fiscal consent.

ARCHIVAL DISPATCHTHE DEATH WARRANT29 January 1649

Warrant for the Execution of King Charles I

"Whereas Charles Stuart, King of England, is and standeth convicted, attainted, and condemned of High Treason and other high crimes... These are therefore to will and require you to see the said sentence executed in the open street before Whitehall, upon the morrow, being the thirtieth day of this instant month of January."

Parliamentary Archives, LondonWestminster Hall, Signed by 59 (HL/PO/JO/10/1/297)Regicides

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT			LESSON 5 SYNTHESIS
1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE: What was meant by the "Divine Right of Kings" and how did Charles I apply this concept to taxation?	2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS: Explain why Parliament viewed Ship Money as an illegal breach of constitutional law.	3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE: "The English Civil War was caused by religious fanaticism, not constitutional disputes over taxation." To what extent do you agree?	

How did a Dutch invasion and the Bank of England turn Britain into a global superpower?

Key Enquiry: How did early modern commerce, religious conflict, and ideological revolution reshape Britain and the globe? • *Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

SECTION 1 THE RISE OF LONDON AS EUROPE'S FINANCIAL METROPOLIS

[1.1] By the mid-seventeenth century, the economic geography of Britain had fundamentally changed. London was no longer merely a royal administrative capital; it was becoming the financial and commercial clearinghouse of global trade. In 1571, merchant financier Sir Thomas Gresham had founded the Royal Exchange in the City of London, modeled on the commercial bourse of Antwerp. Around its open-air marble courtyard, merchants, ship captains, and commodity brokers gathered daily to negotiate wholesale contracts for sugar, tobacco, silk, spices, and maritime cargo space.

[1.2] The River Thames was transformed into a dense forest of wooden ship masts, as merchantmen unloaded raw commodities from the American colonies, the Caribbean, and India. Traditional wealth had always been anchored in rural agricultural land held by hereditary aristocrats. However, by the late seventeenth century, immense fortunes were being accumulated in London through joint-stock trading syndicates, merchant

shipping, and commercial credit, creating an assertive, educated merchant class that demanded political influence and constitutional guarantees for their property.

SOURCE A

CONTEMPORARY Folger Shakespeare Library • Hollar Collection

ARCHITECTURAL ETCHING

Wenceslaus Hollar: The Royal Exchange Courtyard, London (1644)



Hollar's detailed etching shows merchants, ship captains, and brokers congregating in the central courtyard of the Royal Exchange in the City of London, negotiating contracts for tobacco, sugar, textiles, and maritime credit that transformed London into Europe's financial capital.

HINGE QUESTION: How did commercial institutions like the Royal Exchange lay the foundation for Britain's global financial supremacy?

Folger Shakespeare Library • HollarCity of London Historical Commerce Collection Archive

SECTION 2 THE COMMONWEALTH, MERCANTILISM & THE RESTORATION

[2.1] The execution of King Charles I on 30 January 1649 destroyed the traditional doctrine of the Divine Right of Kings, replacing royal authority with the English Commonwealth—history's first major European republic. When the Rump Parliament commissioned the 1651 Great Seal of England, they pointedly erased the monarch's portrait, replacing it with an aerial map of the British Isles and an engraving of the assembled House of Commons under the motto: "In the Third Year of Freedom by God's Blessing Restored."

[2.2] Under Lord Protector Oliver Cromwell, England adopted an aggressive mercantilist commercial doctrine designed to challenge the dominant Dutch maritime trade. Parliament passed the Navigation Act of 1651, dictating that colonial goods could only be transported into England aboard English ships. When the Dutch contested this monopoly, Cromwell launched the First Anglo-Dutch War, deploying the New Model Navy to secure control of the English Channel. Although the

Commonwealth collapsed after Cromwell's death and Charles II was restored to the throne in 1660, the monarchy was permanently stripped of its feudal prerogative courts and could never again govern without parliamentary funding.

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • LESSON 6

COMMONWEALTH

The republican period of English government (1649–1660) established following the execution of King Charles I.

RESTORATION

The return of the Stuart monarchy in 1660 under King Charles II following the collapse of the military Protectorate.

GLORIOUS REVOLUTION

The bloodless overthrow of Catholic King James II in 1688 and the accession of Protestant rulers William and Mary.

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

BILL OF RIGHTS

The landmark 1689 parliamentary act establishing constitutional monarchy and legislative supremacy over royal prerogative.

How did a Dutch invasion and the Bank of England turn Britain into a global superpower?

SECTION 3

THE GLORIOUS REVOLUTION & THE BILL OF RIGHTS (1688–1689)

[3.1] The constitutional tension between crown and parliament flared again during the reign of King James II, an unyielding Catholic who suspended parliamentary statutes and promoted Catholic officers in the army. When James’s wife gave birth to a male Catholic heir in June 1688, threatening a permanent Catholic dynasty, seven leading Protestant politicians sent a secret invitation to Dutch leader William of Orange, urging him to bring an army to preserve English liberties.

[3.2] William landed at Torbay with 15,000 troops in November 1688. James II’s army deserted him, and the King fled into French exile during what became known as the "Glorious Revolution." In exchange for receiving the crown jointly with Queen Mary, Parliament presented William with the Declaration of Rights, codified into the landmark Bill of Rights in December 1689. The statute declared that suspending laws without parliamentary

consent was illegal, barred the monarch from maintaining a peacetime standing army, and established that Parliament possessed exclusive authority to levy taxes, creating Britain’s enduring constitutional monarchy.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

1599–1658



Oliver Cromwell
LORD PROTECTOR OF THE COMMONWEALTH OF ENGLAND, SCOTLAND, AND IRELAND

Forged the New Model Army, crushed royalist forces at Naseby, signed the King’s death warrant, and governed as military dictator (1653–1658).

- DECISIVE ACTIONS:**
- Created the meritocratic New Model Army, promoting officers based on military competence and Puritan religious conviction rather than aristocratic birth.
 - Dismissed the corrupt Rump Parliament at musket-point in 1653, declaring: "You have sat too long for any good you have been doing lately... In the name of God, go!"
 - Instituted the Rule of the Major-Generals, banning theatre, Christmas celebrations, and gambling while securing English naval supremacy over the Dutch.

SECTION 4

THE FINANCIAL REVOLUTION: BANK OF ENGLAND & NATIONAL DEBT

[4.1] The constitutional triumph of Parliament in 1689 triggered the "Financial Revolution" of the 1690s, the institutional engine that enabled Britain to rise as a global superpower. To finance the costly Nine Years' War against Louis XIV of France, Chancellor of the Exchequer Charles Montagu established the Bank of England in 1694. The bank raised a loan of £1.2 million from private London investors in exchange for a royal monopoly on issuing official banknotes and managing government finances.

[4.2] This innovation created the British National Debt, guaranteeing that debt repayments were backed by the full taxing authority of Parliament rather than the fickle personal word of an absolute monarch. Consequently, the British government could borrow vast sums of money at record-low interest rates (3–4%), while French kings were forced to pay ruinous rates of 8–10%. Supported by the burgeoning London Stock Exchange and maritime insurance syndicates meeting in Edward Lloyd’s coffeehouse, Britain established an institutional credit machine that funded the Royal Navy, expanded the British Empire, and created the capital reserves for the Industrial Revolution.

CONSTITUTIONAL REVOLUTION

PARLIAMENTARY SOVEREIGNTY • 1688–1689

The Glorious Revolution & The Bill of Rights

When Catholic King James II produced a male Catholic heir in 1688 and suspended laws against Catholic worship, seven Protestant nobles secretly invited Dutch leader William of Orange to invade England. James fled to France in the bloodless "Glorious Revolution". In exchange for the crown, Parliament required William and Mary to accept the Bill of Rights (1689). The Bill barred monarchs from suspending laws, levying taxes without parliamentary consent, or maintaining a peacetime standing army. This permanently established a constitutional monarchy where Parliament, representing landowning and commercial elites, held supreme legislative power.

Institutional Transformation: The 1689 settlement created institutional stability that made Britain an economic superpower: property rights were guaranteed and royal arbitrary seizure of wealth was abolished.

ARCHIVAL DISPATCH

CONSTITUTIONAL STATUTE

16 December 1689

The English Bill of Rights (1 Will. & Mar. sess. 2 c. 2)

"That the pretended power of suspending the laws or the execution of laws by regal authority without consent of Parliament is illegal; That levying money for or to the use of the Crown by pretence of prerogative, without grant of Parliament, is illegal; That the freedom of speech and debates in Parliament ought not to be impeached."

Parliamentary Archives, Palace of Westminster Statute of the Realm (1689)

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT

LESSON 6 SYNTHESIS

1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE:
Why did the English Commonwealth collapse following the death of Oliver Cromwell in 1658?

2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS:
Explain why the events of 1688 were described by contemporary Protestants as the "Glorious Revolution".

3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE:
Evaluate whether the Bill of Rights (1689) created a democracy or merely transferred power from the monarch to wealthy landowners.

What was the true human cost and commercial scale of the Transatlantic Slave Trade?

Key Enquiry: How did early modern commerce, religious conflict, and ideological revolution reshape Britain and the globe? • Sections 1 & 2:
Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

SECTION 1 ACT 1: CONTEXT & CATALYST (THE HUNGER FOR SWEET GOLD & THE ROYAL AFRICAN COMPANY)

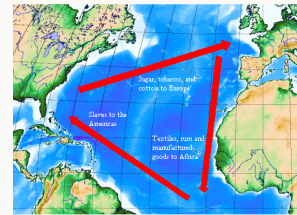
[1.1] [1.1] In the late seventeenth century, British consumer culture was radically transformed by imported imperial luxuries: tea, coffee, chocolate, and above all, **sugar**. Sugar was no longer a rare medicine for royalty; it became a staple food for the working class, sweetening bitter tea to provide quick calories for long factory shifts. But sugarcane was an exceptionally grueling, lethal crop: canes had to be planted, harvested with machetes in tropical heat, crushed in heavy iron mills, and boiled in toxic, bubbling copper vats. When indigenous populations were annihilated by Eurasian disease and European indentured servants proved unable to survive the brutal labor regime, plantation owners turned to the forced labor of enslaved Africans.

[1.2] [1.2] In 1672, King Charles II granted a royal charter creating the **Royal African Company**, headed by his brother James, Duke of York. The company was granted a state monopoly to capture and transport enslaved human beings from West Africa to English colonies in Jamaica, Barbados, and Virginia. The Duke of York personally ordered company captives branded on

the chest with the letters "DoY" or "RAC" using red-hot irons, cementing the horrific reality of chattel slavery: human beings were legally transformed into commercial commodities to be bought, insured, and worked to death for British profit.

SOURCE A HISTORICAL COMMERCIALNational Maritime Museum
CARTOGRAPHY Cartographic Archive

Diagram of the Atlantic Triangular Trade System (18th Century)



British manufactured goods (guns, textiles, metalware) were shipped to West Africa; captured enslaved Africans were forced across the Atlantic via the catastrophic Middle Passage; slave-produced sugar, tobacco, and cotton returned to British ports, enriching merchants and funding the Industrial Revolution.

HINGE QUESTION: How did British domestic manufacturing and global maritime commerce depend entirely on the exploitation of enslaved labour?

National Maritime Museum CartographicTransatlantic Commerce & Plantation
Archive Record

SECTION 2 ACT 2: ESCALATION & CONFLICT (THE TRIANGULAR MACHINE & THE HORROR OF THE MIDDLE PASSAGE)

[2.1] [2.1] By the eighteenth century, British merchants had perfected the **Triangular Trade** (Source A)—a self-reinforcing oceanic machinery operating across three continents. On the **First Leg (Outward Passage)**, ships sailed from Bristol and Liverpool laden with British manufactured goods: flintlock muskets from Birmingham, iron bars, brass pans, gun flints, and Manchester cotton textiles. Arriving at fortified West African slave forts like Cape Coast Castle and Elmina, captains traded these goods to local African monarchs and warlords in exchange for war captives and kidnapped families.

[2.2] [2.2] The **Second Leg (The Middle Passage)** was the most concentrated theatre of human terror in history. Stripped naked and shaved, enslaved men were chained together in pairs by their ankles and wrists and crammed into sweltering, lightless decks beneath the waterline. Captains practiced "tight packing": stacking human

bodies side-by-side on tiered wooden shelves with barely eighteen inches of vertical headroom. Chained in pools of blood, vomit, and human excrement, captives endured six to twelve weeks of horrific torment. Dysentery (the "bloody flux"), smallpox, and ophthalmia raged through the hold; those who went insane were flogged, and those who attempted suicide by starvation were force-fed using the speculum oris, a horrific iron screw device that prized open jaws. Between ten and fifteen percent of all captives died before reaching America, their bodies thrown overboard to following sharks.

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • LESSON 7

TRIANGULAR TRADE

The three-way transatlantic commercial network linking Britain, West Africa, and the Caribbean/American colonies.

MIDDLE PASSAGE

The brutal forced voyage of enslaved Africans across the Atlantic Ocean in overcrowded slave ship holds.

COMMODITY CROP

An agricultural product grown for commercial sale and export on world markets (e.g., sugar, tobacco, cotton).

CHattel SLAVERY

A legal system where human beings are classified as property to be bought, sold, inherited, and forced to labor without pay.

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

What was the true human cost and commercial scale of the Transatlantic Slave Trade?

SECTION 3 ACT 3: FORENSIC ARCHIVAL EVIDENCE (THE GEOMETRY OF THE BROOKES & THE SUGAR PORTS)

[3.1] [3.1] The cold, calculated cruelty of the trade is permanently captured in the famous architectural diagram of the slave ship **Brookes** (Source B). Published in 1788 by abolitionist campaigner Thomas Clarkson, this clinical technical drawing shocked the public conscience: it depicted 454 human beings stowed in precise rows like logs of timber or barrels of rum, allocating a space six feet long by sixteen inches wide for an adult male—literally less room than a corpse inside a wooden coffin. On earlier voyages, the captain admitted to packing over 600 captives into the same hull, proving that human life was treated entirely as disposable cargo.

[3.2] [3.2] Surviving captives who survived the Middle Passage were auctioned like livestock in Kingston, Bridgetown, or Charleston. On the **Third Leg (Home Passage)**, slave ships returned to Britain packed with the raw fruits of unfree labor: hogsheads of raw brown muscovado sugar, barrels of Jamaican rum, crates of

Virginian tobacco, and bales of Carolina cotton. The profits flowed directly into British port cities: Liverpool grew from a fishing village of 5,000 in 1700 into Europe’s premier slave-trading port by 1795, launching over 100 slave ships annually and controlling eighty percent of Britain’s slave trade.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

1760–1846 / c. 1760–1792



Thomas Clarkson & Alexander Falconbridge
LEADING BRITISH ABOLITIONIST ORGANIZERS & EYEWITNESS AUTHORS

Clarkson gathered forensic instruments (manacles, thumbscrews) across British ports, publishing surgeon Falconbridge's devastating 1788 eyewitness testimony on the Middle Passage.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Clarkson traveled 35,000 miles riding across Britain collecting testimonies from sailors, surgeons, and African survivors.
- Falconbridge documented the systematic overcrowding, shackling, forced dancing, and lethal dysentery in ship holds.
- Testified before the Privy Council in 1789, providing the empirical foundation for parliamentary abolition debates.

SECTION 4 ACT 4: THE HISTORICAL VERDICT & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE (THE WILLIAMS THESIS: BLOOD ON THE LOOM)

[4.1] [4.1] In 1944, Trinidadian historian Eric Williams published a groundbreaking masterpiece: *Capitalism and Slavery*. Williams shattered comfortable Victorian narratives that portrayed Britain merely as a noble, compassionate nation that abolished slavery in 1833. Instead, Williams advanced the radical thesis that **the profits of transatlantic slavery financed the Industrial Revolution**. Fortunes amassed in the slave trade built Liverpool’s docks, capitalized private merchant banks like Barclays and Barings, financed the construction of canals and railways, and funded James Watt’s revolutionary steam engine experiments.

[4.2] [4.2] Today, British history directly confronts this legacy. The grand neoclassical buildings of Bristol and Liverpool, the stately country houses of the English aristocracy, and the booming cotton mills of Lancashire were all fertilized by the blood, sweat, and agony of enslaved Africans. Yet enslaved people were never passive victims in this machine; across the ocean, they fought back with ferocious courage.

COMMERCIAL MACHINERY

THE TRIANGULAR SYSTEM • 1650–1807

The Brookes Slave Ship & The Brutal Economics of Commodification

The Transatlantic Slave Trade operated as a highly coordinated three-legged commercial machine: British manufactured goods (Birmingham guns, Sheffield brass, Manchester cottons) sailed to West Africa; captive enslaved Africans were purchased and transported across the Atlantic via the horrific "Middle Passage"; and slave-grown colonial cash crops (sugar, tobacco, cotton, rum) returned to Britain. In 1788, abolitionists published the stowage plan of the Liverpool slave ship **Brookes**, revealing how 454 human beings were packed like cargo into shelves measuring just 6 feet by 16 inches. The diagram shocked public opinion and became history’s first global human rights campaign image.

Economic Reality: The profits of the slave trade enriched British ports (Liverpool, Bristol, London), financed banking institutions (Barclays, Bank of England), and provided cheap capital for the Industrial Revolution.

ARCHIVAL DISPATCH

SURGEON’S MEMOIR

Published 1788

Alexander Falconbridge: An Account of the Slave Trade

"The deck was so covered with the blood and mucus which had proceeded from them in consequence of the flux, that it resembled a slaughter-house. The surgeon upon going between decks in the morning frequently finds several dead... The air soon becomes so heated and tainted that it is unfit for respiration."

British Library, LondonPrinted by J. Phillips, George-Yard, Lombard-Street (T.838/8)

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT			LESSON 7 SYNTHESIS
1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE: Identify the three legs of the Triangular Trade and the specific cargo transported on each leg.	2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS: Explain why the 1788 Brookes slave ship diagram was such an effective campaigning tool for abolitionists.	3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE: Historian Eric Williams argued that the British Empire abolished the slave trade only when it ceased to be profitable, rather than for moral reasons. Assess this economic argument.	

How did enslaved Africans fight back and dismantle the plantation system from within?

Key Enquiry: How did early modern commerce, religious conflict, and ideological revolution reshape Britain and the globe? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

SECTION 1 ACT 1: CONTEXT & CATALYST (THE MYTH OF PASSIVITY & OCEANIC MUTINY)

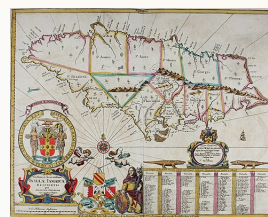
[1.1] [1.1] For centuries, Victorian histories depicted enslaved Africans as silent, passive victims who waited patiently for noble white parliamentarians like William Wilberforce to set them free. Modern scholarship has obliterated this myth. In truth, African resistance began the very second captives were ambushed in their homelands and continued relentlessly at every stage of their enslavement. Captives rebelled in coastal barracoons, leapt overboard into shark-infested waters to drown as free people rather than submit to chains, and launched armed mutinies aboard slave ships.

[1.2] [1.2] Shipboard insurrections were remarkably frequent: maritime records prove that violent revolts broke out on at least ten percent of all slave voyages across the Atlantic. Captives smuggled barrel hoops to pick locks, attacked crews with broken shackles, and in famous cases like the *Clara* (1729) or the *Amistad* (1839), overpowered the white crew and seized control of the ship. Knowing that mutinies could erupt at any moment,

British captains invested in heavily armed crew barricades with swivel cannons aimed directly at the slave deck, terrified of their own human cargo.

SOURCE A CONTEMPORARY MILITARY National Library of Jamaica Archives
ENGRAVING

Abraham Brunias: Leonard Parkinson, Captain of the Maroons (1796)



Engraved during the Second Maroon War in Jamaica, this print shows Leonard Parkinson, a Maroon guerrilla commander, armed with a cutlass and brace of pistols. Jamaican Maroons defeated British regular armies, forcing the Crown to sign treaties recognizing Maroon freedom.

HINGE QUESTION: How did Jamaican Maroon resistance prove that freedom was seized by Africans through combat rather than granted by British politicians?

National Library of Jamaica Caribbean Resistance & Emancipation Archives Papers

SECTION 2 ACT 2: ESCALATION & CONFLICT (THE SPECTRUM OF RESISTANCE & THE MAROON GUERRILLAS)

[2.1] [2.1] Once sold onto American and Caribbean plantations, enslaved people engaged in a continuous **spectrum of resistance**. Subtle daily resistance was universal: laborers worked slowly, feigned illness, deliberately broke expensive sugarcane machetes, sabotaged sugar boiling houses, and preserved banned African languages, drumming, and religious traditions like Obeah. Women used herbal knowledge to administer secret abortifacients rather than bear children into lifelong chattel bondage. On a more dangerous level, enslaved rebels plotted armed uprisings, such as the **Stono Rebellion** in South Carolina (1739), where eighty enslaved men marched toward Spanish Florida beating drums and shouting for liberty.

[2.2] [2.2] The most formidable armed resistance emerged in Jamaica among the **Maroons**—communities of self-liberated Africans who fled into the impenetrable limestone ravines of the Cockpit Country and the misty heights of the Blue Mountains (Source A). Led by a

brilliant military and spiritual leader named Queen Nanny, the Windward Maroons waged a savage guerrilla war against the British military throughout the 1730s. Disguising themselves with leafy branches, ambushing redcoats from mountain ledges, and communicating across valleys using a cow horn called the *abeng*, Nanny's warriors slaughtered British regiments sent to re-enslave them.

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • LESSON 8

INSURRECTION

An organized, violent uprising or rebellion by enslaved people seeking freedom from plantation owners or ship crews.

MAROONS

Communities of self-liberated formerly enslaved Africans who established autonomous settlements in mountain and forest terrain.

ABOLITIONISM

The social and political movement dedicated to outlawing the slave trade and completely emancipating enslaved people.

ABENG

A traditional cow-horn bugle used by Jamaican Maroons for long-distance military signaling and acoustic camouflage.

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

How did enslaved Africans fight back and dismantle the plantation system from within?

SECTION 3 ACT 3: FORENSIC ARCHIVAL EVIDENCE (THE 1739 TREATY & EQUIANO'S BESTSELLING WEAPON)

[3.1] [3.1] Primary documents reveal the humiliating retreat of British imperial power in the face of Maroon warfare. By 1739, colonial governor Edward Trelawny realized the British army could never defeat Queen Nanny's guerrilla fighters. In the landmark **Treaty of 1739** (Source A), the British Crown formally recognized the Maroons as free people, granting them 1,500 acres of sovereign land and total autonomy—nearly a century before the abolition of slavery in the British Empire! Queen Nanny is celebrated today as Jamaica's only female National Hero.

[3.2] [3.2] In Britain, the weapon of resistance was the pen. In 1789, Olaudah Equiano—a former enslaved Igbo man who had survived the Middle Passage and bought his freedom—published his bestselling autobiography: *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano* (Source B). Depicted on the frontispiece dressed in fine Georgian attire holding a Bible, Equiano delivered a

devastating blow to pro-slavery propagandists who claimed Africans were subhuman. Equiano joined the **Sons of Africa**, a political group of free Black Londoners that included Ottobah Cugoano, traveling across Britain giving fiery public lectures and personally lobbying Parliament.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

c. 1686–c. 1755



Queen Nanny of the Maroons

MILITARY STRATEGIST & CHIEFTAINESS OF THE WINDWARD JAMAICAN MAROONS

Led escaped enslaved Africans in brilliant guerrilla warfare against British colonial troops in Jamaica, forcing the British Crown to sign a peace treaty in 1739.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Organized fortified mountain strongholds in the impenetrable Blue Mountains (Nanny Town) as autonomous free communities.
- Employed expert camouflage, ambush tactics, and acoustic communication via cow-horn (*abeng*) to defeat superior British regular regiments.
- Secured the 1739 British-Maroon Treaty granting the Windward Maroons 500 acres of autonomous land and permanent freedom from enslavement.

SECTION 4 ACT 4: THE HISTORICAL VERDICT & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE (WHO TRULY ABOLISHED SLAVERY?)

[4.1] [4.1] Historians remain engaged in a profound debate over what truly destroyed the Transatlantic Slave Trade in 1807. Traditional imperial historians credited white parliamentary reformers like William Wilberforce and Thomas Clarkson, celebrating British abolition as a triumph of Christian morality. Conversely, revisionist historians, beginning with Eric Williams and advanced by scholars like Professor Hilary Beckles, argue that the trade collapsed because enslaved rebellions made the Caribbean impossible to control. Constant slave uprisings made plantation insurance costs skyrocket and required thousands of British troops to suppress, rendering unfree labor an economic liability.

[4.2] [4.2] What is indisputable is that without the courageous resistance of enslaved Africans—from the fierce guerrilla warfare of Queen Nanny to the eloquent literature of Olaudah Equiano—the abolition of the slave trade would never have occurred. Their courage proved that human dignity could never be extinguished by chains, whips, or commercial ledgers.

AGENCY & RESISTANCE

THE SPECTRUM OF OPPOSITION • 1700–1800

The Spectrum of Resistance: From Overt Rebellion to Cultural Survival

Enslaved Africans were never passive victims of the plantation system; they fought back through an expansive spectrum of resistance. Overt resistance included shipboard mutinies (recorded on roughly 10% of all Atlantic slave voyages) and armed insurrections such as the 1739 Stono Rebellion in South Carolina and the Jamaican Maroon Wars. Covert day-to-day resistance was even more widespread: feigning illness, breaking sugar-milling machinery, sabotaging crops, learning to read in secret, preserving West African religious rituals, and establishing escape networks.

Historical Insight: Resistance imposed immense military and financial costs on slave-owners, undermining the security and profitability of the plantation economy long before official abolition in 1807.

ARCHIVAL DISPATCH

AUTOBIOGRAPHICAL TESTIMONY

Published 1789

The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano

"The stench of the hold while we were on the coast was so intolerably loathsome, that it was dangerous to remain there for any time... The shrieks of the women, and the groans of the dying, rendered the whole a scene of horror almost inconceivable. I often wished for the last friend, death, to relieve me."

Printed for and Sold by the Author, No. 10 Union-Street

London, 1789

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT

1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE:

Explain the difference between overt resistance and covert resistance on 18th-century slave plantations.

2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS:

How did Queen Nanny and the Jamaican Maroons exploit their geography to defeat British colonial armies?

3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE:

Evaluate the role of Black abolitionists like Olaudah Equiano in changing British public opinion on the slave trade.

LESSON 8 SYNTHESIS

How 'modern' was Britain by 1750? (Synthesis & Assessment)

Key Enquiry: How did early modern commerce, religious conflict, and ideological revolution reshape Britain and the globe? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

SECTION 1 ACT 1: CONTEXT & CATALYST (THE GREAT TRANSFORMATION: 1450 VS. 1750)

[1.1] [1.1] In 1450, England was an insular, impoverished medieval kingdom on the fringes of Europe: recovering from the Black Death, torn apart by feudal baronies, with an unpaved capital of 50,000 citizens and zero overseas colonies. By 1750, three centuries later, Britain had undergone the most astonishing metamorphosis in human history. London was now a sprawling imperial metropolis of nearly 700,000 citizens—the financial, commercial, and maritime capital of the Western world. British merchant ships dominated every major oceanic trade route, the Royal Navy was the undisputed master of the seas, and British rule spanned from the sugar islands of the Caribbean to the trading factories of Bengal.

[1.2] [1.2] Domestically, Britain appeared to be the beacon of political stability and intellectual enlightenment. While absolute monarchs in France, Spain, and Russia ruled without parliaments, Britain was a constitutional monarchy governed by the rule of law, protected by the 1689 Bill of Rights. The Scientific Revolution and the Scottish Enlightenment had replaced medieval superstition with Newtonian physics and

empirical science. Wealthy Britons enjoyed a "consumer revolution": drinking Jamaican sugar and Chinese tea from porcelain cups in elegant Georgian salons furnished with mahogany tables, discussing literature and global politics in comfortable townhouses.

SOURCE A IMPERIAL CEILING Foreign and Commonwealth Office Collection, London

PAINTING

Spiridione Roma: The East Offering Its Riches to Britannia (1778)



Commissioned for the East India Company's headquarters in London, Roma's painting depicts kneeling Asian figures presenting pearls, tea, and jewels to Britannia, projecting an image of voluntary tribute and benevolent British rule while concealing military plunder.

HINGE QUESTION: How does this artwork reflect Britain's self-image as a benevolent civilizing power while concealing the violence of colonial conquest?

Foreign and Commonwealth Office Collection, East India Company Directors' Archive
London

SECTION 2 ACT 2: ESCALATION & CONFLICT (THE DUAL REALITY: IMPERIAL WEALTH ALLEGORY)

[2.1] [2.1] The ascending wealth of the British Empire was celebrated through grandiose allegorical art. In Spiridione Roma's ceiling painting for the East India Company, The East Offering its Riches to Britannia (Source A), Britain is depicted as a regal classical goddess receiving the voluntary homage of the world: personifications of India and China kneel humbly, pouring out pearls, jewels, and tea chests. It was the ultimate corporate propaganda: an image of benign, peaceful commerce that completely erased the brutal realities of naval cannon, military coercion, and colonial famine.

[2.2] [2.2] Yet beneath this glittering veneer of Georgian enlightenment lay a dark, deeply divided society. Britain's commercial wealth was concentrated in the hands of a tiny oligarchy of landed aristocrats, London bankers, and Caribbean plantation owners. Enclosure acts had driven hundreds of thousands of

landless agricultural laborers into squalid urban slums like St Giles, where whole families were packed into damp, airless cellar dwellings without running water or sanitation.

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • LESSON 9

URBANIZATION

The demographic process whereby an increasing proportion of a nation's population shifts from rural villages to cities.

ENLIGHTENMENT

The 18th-century European intellectual movement emphasizing reason, empirical science, and individual liberty.

NATIONAL DEBT

The total amount of money borrowed by the British government from private investors backed by parliamentary taxes.

MERCANTILISM

An economic theory holding that national power depends on maximizing exports, accumulating bullion, and strictly controlling colonial trade.

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

How 'modern' was Britain by 1750? (Synthesis & Assessment)

SECTION 3 ACT 3: FORENSIC ARCHIVAL EVIDENCE (THE SQUALOR OF GIN LANE & DOMESTIC INEQUALITY)

[3.1] [3.1] The psychological despair of the urban poor exploded in the catastrophic "Gin Craze" of the 1730s and 1740s. Unregulated corn spirits flooded the capital: Londoners consumed over eleven million gallons of gin a year. In squalid alleyways, "dram shops" advertised that customers could get "Drunk for a penny, dead drunk for twopence, with straw for nothing!" Infant mortality soared: in the poorest London parishes, three out of four children died before their fifth birthday.

[3.2] [3.2] The brutal reality of domestic Britain is permanently recorded in William Hogarth's searing 1751 masterpiece Gin Lane (Source B). Set in the notorious St Giles slum, Hogarth depicts an apocalyptic scene of social disintegration: an intoxicated mother drops her baby from a staircase to its death, while a skeletal ballad singer starves and an impoverished soldier pawns his sword for

one more dram of liquor. Far from an enlightened modern paradise, 1750 Britain was a society of grotesque extremes: colossal imperial fortunes built alongside desperate domestic destitution.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

1642–1727



Sir Isaac Newton

PHYSICIST, MATHEMATICIAN, PRESIDENT OF THE ROYAL SOCIETY & MASTER OF THE MINT

Formulated the laws of universal gravitation and motion, anchoring the Scientific Revolution and modern empirical rationalism.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Published the **Philosophiae Naturalis Principia Mathematica** (1687), proving that the universe was governed by rational, predictable mathematical laws.
- Appointed Master of the Royal Mint in 1699, aggressively prosecuting counterfeiters and reforming English gold and silver coinage.
- Served as President of the Royal Society for twenty-four years, establishing London as Europe's capital of scientific experimentation and technological enquiry.

SECTION 4 ACT 4: THE HISTORICAL VERDICT & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE (THE VERDICT ON 1750: MODERNITY OR EXPLOITATION?)

[4.1] [4.1] Historians remain divided over whether 1750 Britain should be celebrated as the world's first "modern" society. Liberal constitutional historians emphasize the positive transformation: Britain was the pioneer of parliamentary democracy, the rule of law, religious toleration, and capitalist innovation, providing the political and financial stability that would soon launch the Industrial Revolution.

[4.2] [4.2] Conversely, social and post-colonial historians argue that Britain's "modernity" was an illusion enjoyed only by a wealthy elite. They emphasize that the British Empire was built on the enslavement of over three million Africans, the violent dispossession of indigenous nations in America, and the commercial plunder of India, while its own working class perished in squalor. The year 1750 was not the end of Britain's transformation, but the launchpad for a new industrial world that would export British power, industry, and empire to every corner of the earth.

INSTITUTIONAL FOUNDATIONS

THE FISCAL-MILITARY STATE • 1694–1750

The Financial Revolution & The Foundation of the Bank of England

In 1694, Parliament chartered the Bank of England to raise a loan of £1.2 million to finance the war against Louis XIV's France. This created the National Debt: investors lent money to the government backed by parliamentary taxation, receiving reliable interest payments. Alongside the London Stock Exchange and maritime insurance (Lloyd's of London), Britain pioneered a "Financial Revolution". While absolute French monarchs struggled to raise loans at exorbitant 10% interest rates due to fear of royal bankruptcy, the British constitutional Crown borrowed millions at 3–4%, allowing a relatively small island nation to maintain the world's most powerful Royal Navy.

Strategic Advantage: Britain's emergence as a global empire was built not just on gunpowder and courageous sailors, but on superior institutional finance, parliamentary taxation, and state credit.

ARCHIVAL DISPATCH

TRAVEL NARRATIVE & SOCIAL

SURVEY

Published

1724

Daniel Defoc: A Tour Through the Whole Island of Great Britain

"Trade in England neither arranges nor degrades, but ennobles the practitioner... The commerce of this island is an inexhaustible fund of wealth; it supplies the fleets, it pays the armies, and it makes the British nation feared and respected throughout the habitable globe."

Printed for G. Bickerston, Survey of English Commerce and Agriculture
London (1724)

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT

LESSON 9 SYNTHESIS

1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL & EVIDENCE:

How did the foundation of the Bank of England in 1694 transform British military and naval power?

2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS:

Explain why William Hogarth's "Beer Street and Gin Lane" (1751) illustrates both the prosperity and poverty of modernizing London.

3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION & DEBATE:

"By 1750, Britain had become a thoroughly modern nation." Assess the validity of this statement, considering politics, science, and social inequality.

THE EARLY MODERN WORLD • CHRONOLOGY & DISCIPLINARY GUIDE

Master Sequence of Events, Core Terminology & Historical Analysis Framework

MASTER CHRONOLOGICAL SEQUENCE (1450–1750)

29 May 1453: Ottoman forces capture Constantinople; Byzantine Empire falls.	1492: Christopher Columbus lands in the Americas; Spanish colonization begins.	1517: Martin Luther nails Ninety-Five Theses; Protestant Reformation ignites.
1545: Spanish discover the Cerro Rico silver mountain at Potosí, Bolivia.	1588: English navy and fireships defeat the Spanish Armada at Gravelines.	31 Dec 1600: Elizabeth I grants royal charter to the English East India Company.
5 Nov 1605: Gunpowder Plot discovered beneath Parliament; Guy Fawkes arrested.	1629–1640: King Charles I rules without Parliament ("Eleven Years' Tyranny").	1642–1646: First English Civil War; Royalist Cavaliers vs Parliamentary Roundheads.
30 Jan 1649: King Charles I executed for high treason outside Whitehall; Republic declared.	1653–1658: Oliver Cromwell rules as Lord Protector of the Commonwealth.	May 1660: Restoration of the Stuart Monarchy under King Charles II.
1688: Glorious Revolution; William and Mary overthrow Catholic King James II.	Dec 1689: Bill of Rights passed, establishing permanent constitutional monarchy.	1694: Bank of England founded to finance imperial war and National Debt.
1739: British Crown signs peace treaty with Jamaican Maroons under Queen Nanny.	1750: Britain commands global trade, urbanizing cities, and transatlantic empire.	1788–89: Brookes plan published; Equiano publishes slave trade narrative.

KEY CONCEPTUAL THREADS FOR KS3 HISTORICAL EXPLANATION

1 • Global Connectedness The transition from isolated regional empires to an interconnected global economy driven by maritime shipping, spices, silver, and sugar.	2 • Power & Sovereignty The profound shift from absolute Divine Right of Kings to parliamentary supremacy, rule of law, and institutional checks and balances.	3 • Empire & Exploitation The devastating human cost of commercial expansion, particularly the chattel enslavement and violent commodification of 12.5 million Africans.	4 • Resistance & Agency How colonized and enslaved peoples actively resisted European domination through open warfare, maroon autonomy, sabotage, and cultural survival.
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KEY HISTORIOGRAPHICAL PERSPECTIVES ON EARLY MODERN BRITAIN

Whig Interpretation (Progress & Liberty): Views 1688 and the Bill of Rights as the glorious triumph of English parliamentary freedom, rationalism, and constitutional democracy over royal tyranny.

Revisionist & Postcolonial Interpretation: Emphasizes that Britain's "liberty" was funded by the brutal profits of the Transatlantic Slave Trade, Indian colonial extortion, and domestic working-class exploitation.